

A Talk Is an Evaluation Story

DATA 443/643 · Week 14, note 14.3

Week 14

American University

Ahmad Mousavi

Talk craft from Peyton Jones; numbers from this course. Original slides.

Lecture plan

- 1 A metric that could change your mind
- 2 Baseline, split, n, seeds
- 3 +2 pp vs 4 pp of seed noise
- 4 One failure case with ids

Key goal: question, table, ablation, failure. Not a notebook tour.

First time: what / why / formula

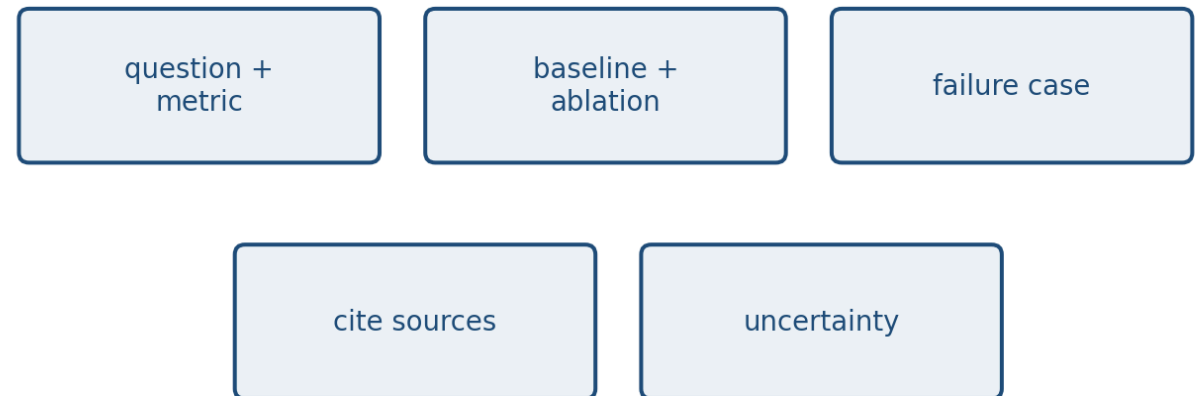
- What / why. Question, method, one number that could change your mind, an ablation, one inspected failure. A notebook tour is not reproducible. Reviewers (and this class) need a falsifiable claim.
- Architecture. Slides: claim → table (baseline vs yours, n , seeds) → ablation → failure with ids.
- Formula. If mean lift is +2 pp and seed spread is 4 pp on $n = 50$, you did not beat noise. Do not lead with that bump.
- Tradeoffs. + Honest talks travel. – You will show a miss; that is the point. Screenshots are not a method.

How. Pick the metric first (recall@k, exact match, ASR). Freeze the split. Mean lift vs seed spread.

Write a falsifiable sentence

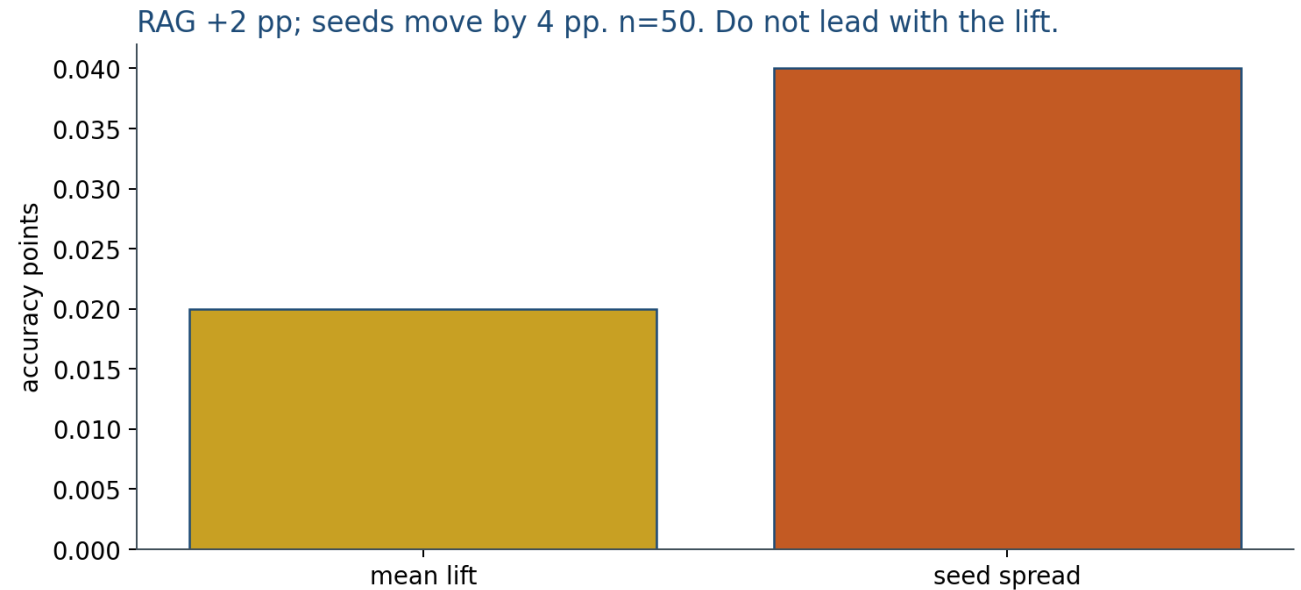
- Name the knob, the split, and n.
- A demo GIF is not a substitute for a number.
- If a closed API is in the loop, still show an open baseline.

A talk is an evaluation story, not a gallery of screenshots



Do not lead with a 2-point bump

- RAG 0.82 and 0.78 (mean 0.80).
Baseline 0.80 and 0.76 (mean 0.78).
- Lift 0.02. Seed spread 0.04. n=50.
- Say that out loud. Then show a failure
RAG actually changed.



Ablation vs theater

Fake ablation

You claimed LoRA; you turned off dropout. That was not the claim.

Real ablation

Turn off the claimed knob (no retrieval, $k=1$, no CoT) and show the metric move.

If one minute remains

Drop this

A second architecture diagram the back row cannot read.

Keep this

The failure: query, retrieved ids, what broke.

What to take from this lecture

Spine

30 s question, 1 min picture, 1 min table, 1 min failure.

Canvas

Slot and upload are official. Week 15 leftover talks too.

Peyton Jones

Start with the problem. Mechanism later.